Hand a teenager a real cost. Ask them to fix it.

Barrier Breakers · Northeast Ohio's high school entrepreneurship competition · fourth year



Budgeting advice doesn't fix a $400 ER bill or rent that eats half a paycheck. A student who has lived those costs might. Barrier Breakers gives Northeast Ohio high schoolers a real barrier to financial health, a few months to build something that breaks it, and a room full of local business leaders to pitch it to. The best ventures leave with cash.

8,000

Students FinMango teaches in person each year across 25+ Akron, Canton, and Cleveland-area high schools. That is where teams come from.

250

Students in the room on March 20, 2026: 104 teams, judged by 12 volunteer professionals in one day.

$20K+

Awarded in 2026 to winning teams and their schools. Sponsors fund it. FinMango is all-volunteer, so nearly every dollar reaches students.

01 · FIND THE COST

Pick a barrier

Healthcare, housing, transportation, financial literacy, or one the team has noticed. Research who it hurts and what it costs them.

02 · BUILD

Make it real

An app, a product, a service, a policy. Work out who pays and who runs it. Bring a prototype, not a slide about one.

03 · PITCH

Sixty seconds, then questions

Three judges at every table. Five finalists present to the whole room at Demo Day. Cash goes straight to the teams.

104 teams. Five barriers.

Open track	32
Healthcare access	20
Financial literacy	19
Housing	17
Transportation	16

Teams of one to three students, grades 9 to 12, from nine schools across Summit, Stark, Cuyahoga, and Medina counties. Source: 2026 team applications.

What the judges saw

A medical bill analyzer that reads a bill, flags errors, and finds assistance. *"Solves a real problem that costs Americans billions, and they've built it."*

A paycheck scanner that turns a pay stub into a budget. *"I love the paycheck scanning."*

Low-cost rides to medical appointments, built with hospitals and insurers in mind.

A tax-credit tool that automates an existing, rarely used IRS code. *"No new laws needed."*

Surplus food to hungry families, modeled on programs that work abroad. *"Already developed beyond the idea stage."*

Where a $25,000 sponsorship budget goes

$17,500
Cash prizes to the five Demo Day teams and the honorable mentions

$5,000
The day: breakfast, lunch, and materials for 250 students, teachers, and judges

$2,500
Venue, AV, printing, insurance, and a reserve



The gallery round: sixty seconds to make the case, then questions.



Demo Day: five finalists, five minutes each, in front of every student in the room.

Sponsor Barrier Breakers 2027

Spring 2027 · Northeast Ohio · date and host campus announced with sponsors

Platinum · presenting	**$25,000**	The event is "powered by" you across the site, banners, flyers, and student handouts. Stage time at the awards, seats on the judging panel, first call on 2028.
Gold	**$10,000**	Funds several student prizes in your name. Logo on the site and event banners, a judging seat, recognition from the stage.
Event Day Sponsor	**$5,000**	Covers the day: breakfast, lunch, and materials for 250 students plus teachers and judges. Logo on the site and program, signage at the meals, a judging seat.
Silver	**$2,500**	Logo on the site and in the printed program, and an invitation to judge.
Name a prize	**Any**	Fund first place or the honorable mentions, announced that way at the awards.

Levels are a starting point. A named prize, a sponsored lunch, or more of your team on the floor as judges can all be built around you.

Commitment

- ☐ Platinum · $25,000
- ☐ Gold · $10,000
- ☐ Event Day · $5,000
- ☐ Silver · $2,500
- ☐ Name a prize · $ _____

Company _____

Contact name and title _____

Email and phone _____

Mailing address _____

Name as it should appear _____

Employees interested in judging _____

Signature and date _____

Return this page to competition@finmango.org. **Checks** payable to FinMango, 1410 Gray Fox Drive, North Canton, OH 44720. FinMango is a 501(c)(3) public charity, EIN 81-2543425; W-9 on request.

Logos are due four weeks before the event, as SVG, EPS, or PDF.

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